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Out of tragedy comes a new leader. That seems to be the script that has been written for political dynasties in South Asia. Whether it is Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, India or Pakistan, the death of a political leader has always been a signal for another member of the family concerned to be catapulted into frontline politics. India and Pakistan share that history to a greater degree. The saga of the Gandhis and the Bhuttos has many parallels. Three members of the Gandhi family died in tragic circumstances: a mother and two sons, of which two served as prime ministers. The Bhuttos have lost four, a father, two sons and now, Benazir. Two of the Bhuttos became prime ministers.

Now, after Benazir's death, another son, Bilawal, has made a fiery political baptism as titular head of the Pakistan People's Party (PPP) but in reality, it is father, Asif Zardari, who is the power behind the throne, much like Sonia Gandhi. Like her, he is poised to play a crucial role in Pakistan politics in the near future. He is the cynosure of all eyes in Pakistan in the context of the coming elections and, as our cover story reveals, the sympathy wave after his wife's death has not receded but only grown. The PPP, if the elections are free and fair as President Pervez Musharraf has pledged, will be the deciding factor in the formation of the next government. That makes Zardari a key figure in any post-election scenario and why we have chosen to put him on this cover.



Zardari with Chengappa and Zaidi

In India, very little is known about the man apart from his image of a polo-playing playboy who was called Mr Ten Per Cent for his alleged deals and for which he has spent 11 years behind bars. I was seated next to him at a dinner table in Davos in 1994 where he was accompanying his prime minister wife. He came across as a jovial, devil-may-care fellow who was not overawed by his wife's position. It was a fun-filled evening full of banter about our two countries. I recall him saying: "Why don't you just give us Kashmir and get it over with." I am sure he is more serious now. In the weeks after Benazir's assassination, he has conducted himself with grace and gravitas and played his political cards with a great deal of savvy. He made his son PPP chairman, appointed a respected senior leader as the prime ministerial candidate, called for a consensus on key issues among political parties and offered to team up with Benazir's main rival, Nawaz Sharif.

To put together a profile of the man and his importance in the emerging political scenario in Pakistan, Managing Editor Raj Chengappa and our Pakistan contributor Hasan Zaidi, travelled to Larkana to probe him on his ambitions, his image and his future role. "He has a very impressive grasp of the key issues", says Chengappa. Zardari's political life has been a controversial but fascinating journey and our cover story looks at the man who could be Pakistan's Kingmaker if not King.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)